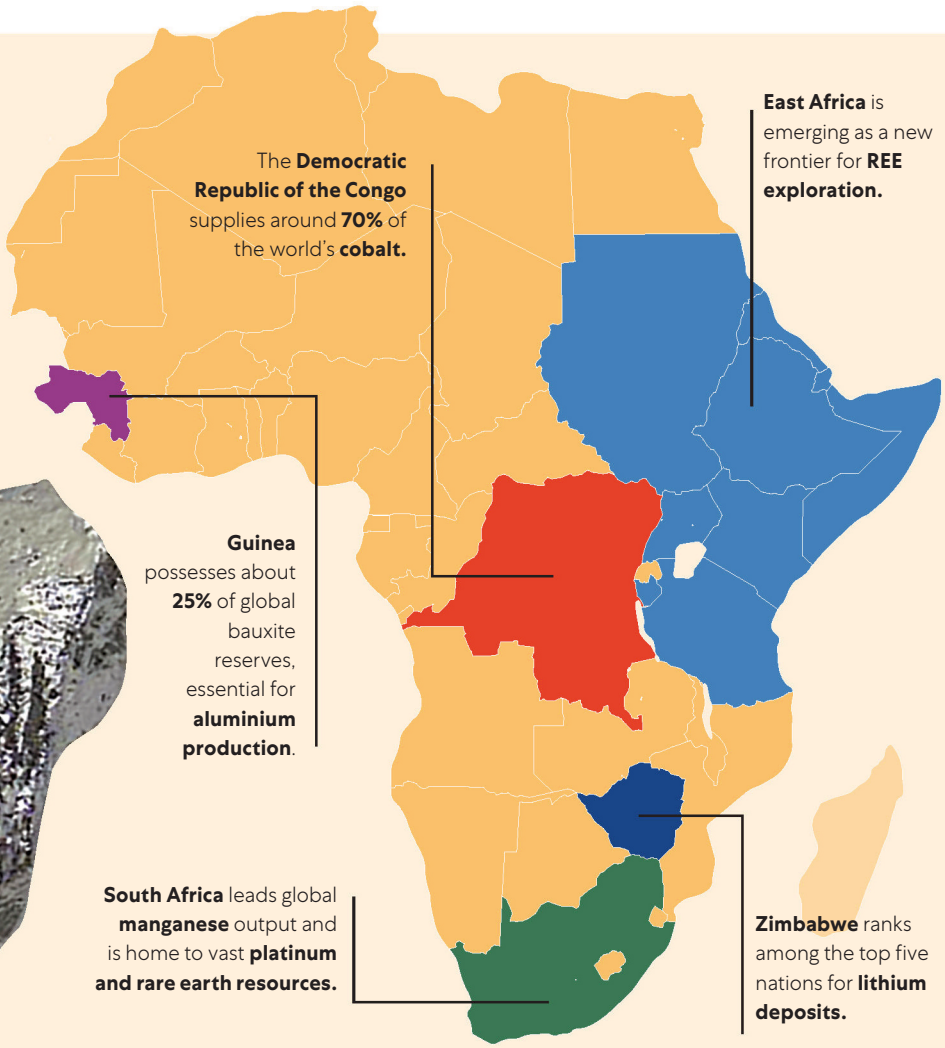
Africa's mineral advantage

Africa's resource endowment is staggering. The continent holds approximately 30% of the world's critical mineral reserves, including cobalt, lithium, manganese, bauxite, and platinum group metals (PGMs). According to the Africa Policy Research Institute, between 2019 and 2023, African nations signed more than 100 bilateral and multilateral agreements related to critical minerals, evidence of intense global interest.





A global race for green power

The energy transition is not new to human civilisation. From wood to coal, coal to oil, and now oil to renewables. What makes this transition different is its urgency. If global temperature rise is not curbed by 2030, the consequences for ecosystems and economies alike will be irreversible.

Critical minerals lie at the centre of this transformation. The World Bank estimates that the demand for lithium, graphite, and cobalt could increase by nearly 500% by 2050, driven by electric vehicles and renewable energy storage systems. Yet, the supply of these minerals is highly concentrated.

China dominates 50–70% of global refining for lithium and cobalt, and nearly 90% of REE processing, according to the International Energy Agency (IEA). The geopolitical implications are profound as control over critical minerals now translates into control over the technologies of the future.

But investment in the sector is slowing. IEA data shows that global spending on critical minerals grew by just 5% in 2024, compared to 14% in 2023, signalling caution amid market volatility and regulatory uncertainty. This slowdown threatens to delay the very green transition the world urgently needs.

Policy shifts and strategic frameworks

Governments worldwide are racing to secure their place in the critical minerals value chain. Since 2022, the IEA's Critical Minerals Policy Tracker has documented over 450 national policies across more than 35 countries, many aimed at reducing environmental and social harms while securing supply.

South Africa took a significant step in 2025, approving its Critical Minerals Strategy, designed to leverage national strengths in PGMs, lithium, and cobalt to advance the country's energy transition. Similar strategies are emerging in Namibia, Zimbabwe, and Zambia, each aiming to add local value, attract sustainable investment, and avoid the historical pitfalls of extractive dependency.

However, these strategies also signal a new geopolitical playbook. Competition over critical minerals is reshaping foreign policy, trade alliances, and even security doctrines. As nations jostle for access, there is a growing risk that the benefits of Africa's mineral wealth will once again bypass its people.

The new scramble for Africa's minerals

The African Union's African Mining Vision (2009) and Commodities Strategy (2019) both call for value addition, regional integration, and industrial development, yet implementation remains uneven. The establishment of the African Minerals Development Centre in 2016 was a step forward, but translating strategy into tangible beneficiation remains Africa's defining challenge.

With global critical mineral revenues projected to reach US$400 billion annually by 2050, Africa stands at a crossroads: it can either replicate the extractive patterns of the oil era or rewrite the rules for equitable and sustainable growth.

Africa's mineral wealth is not merely geological; it is geopolitical. The continent's role in supplying the raw materials for the digital and green revolutions gives it unprecedented bargaining power, but only if it acts collectively and strategically.

The G20's responsibility and the path forward

At this year's G20 Summit, South Africa's Minister of Mineral and Petroleum Resources, Gwede Mantashe, proposed a Critical Minerals Framework, a crucial step toward global accountability. Many G20 nations are both the largest emitters of carbon dioxide and the biggest consumers of critical minerals. Aligning their consumption patterns with just, transparent, and sustainable sourcing is